

Nine ways to write one word.

Every box below says **mother**. Say them out loud — they all sound almost the same, *maa* or *amma*. Same word. Same sound. Nine different pictures.

A  maa	B  ammaa	C  maa
D  amma	E  maa	F  maa
G  amma	H  maa	I  amma

Your clue

Odia was written with an iron stylus on a dried palm leaf. A straight line cut along the grain would slit the leaf in two — so Odia letters learned to **curve**. Look for the roundest one. Look for the umbrella on top.

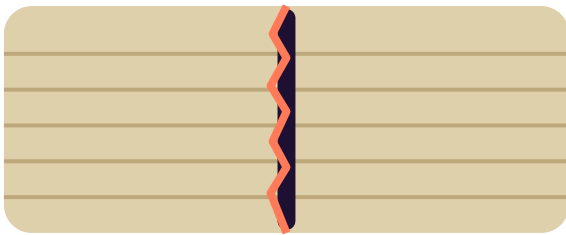


Which one is Odia?

Write the letter, then come and check at the screen.

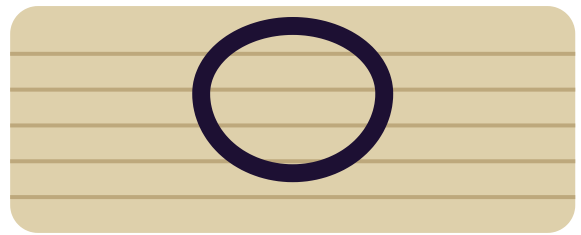
Why is Odia round?

Because for centuries it was not written on paper. It was scratched into a dried palm leaf with an iron stylus — and a palm leaf has a grain, like wood.



✗ it splits

A **straight line** runs with the grain and slices the leaf clean in two. Your page falls apart in your hands.



✓ it holds

A **curve** keeps crossing the grain and never follows it far enough to tear. So the letters curved — and stayed curved.

HINDI • PAPER

क ख ग घ

A straight bar across the top.

ODIA • PALM LEAF

କ ଖ ଗ ଘ

The same four letters, wearing umbrellas.

Every Odia letter is carrying a **1,000-year-old workaround** for a stationery problem. The leaf is long gone. The curve stayed.

1 2 3 is not the only way.

Odia keeps its own set of ten digits, and they are still printed on buses, exam papers and calendars in Odisha today.

୦ 0 shuunya	୧ 1 eka	୨ 2 dui	୩ 3 tini	୪ 4 chaari
୫ 5 paancha	୬ 6 chhaa	୭ 7 saata	୮ 8 aatha	୯ 9 naa

Write the year you were born.

One Odia digit per box. Check it against the table above — no peeking at a phone.



That circle is a big deal. Treating zero as a number you can actually calculate with — add it, subtract it, and state the rules — was worked out in India. Brahmagupta set those rules down in **628 CE**, centuries before the idea reached Europe. Every empty box you have ever left blank on a maths paper owes it something.

Three things, two minutes each.

Everything runs on this Mac. Pick any one — you don't have to start at the top.

1



Talk to Smruti

Put the headset on and have a real conversation. She'll teach you words to say back.

- Try: "**How do you say hello?**" · "Teach me to count." · "Tell me something about Odisha."
- Then **say the Odia word back to her**.

2



Odia letters & words

Tap anything on screen to hear it spoken. No headset needed — just look and listen.

Say hello

Vowels

Letters

Numbers

Colours

Family

3



Your name in Odia

Type your name and watch it turn into Odia writing — then hear it read back.

- Take a card from the table and **copy your name onto it by hand** before you go.

One honest thing

Ask Smruti anything **in English** — she will answer **in Odia** and explain. That is not a gimmick: the speech system behind her only understands English ears, so English in, Odia out. She also **can't mark your pronunciation**. She will cheer you on regardless, which is roughly what a grandmother would do anyway.

Odia and German are cousins. Tamil is not — and still says *amma*.

Every word below means **mother**. They fall into two families that have never been related to each other. Both families arrived at an **m**.

Family one · Indo-European

One ancestor language, spoken north of the Black Sea about 6,000 years ago. Nobody wrote it down — linguists reconstructed it backwards from its children.

RECONSTRUCTED ANCESTOR

***méh₂tēr**

ODIA ମା <i>maa</i>	HINDI माँ <i>maa</i>	SANSKRIT मातृ <i>mātr</i>	GREEK μήτηρ <i>mētēr</i>
LATIN mater <i>mah-ter</i>	GERMAN Mutter <i>moo-ter</i>	SPANISH madre <i>mah-dreh</i>	FRENCH mère <i>mehr</i>

Family two · Dravidian

Older in India than the family above, and completely unrelated to it. All four are spoken next door to Odisha.

RECONSTRUCTED ANCESTOR

***amma**

TAMIL அம்மா <i>ammaa</i>	TELUGU అమ్మ <i>amma</i>	KANNADA ಅಮ್ಮ <i>amma</i>	MALAYALAM അമ്മ <i>amma</i>
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So why do both families sound the same?

Because babies do. **M** is the easiest consonant a human mouth makes — lips together, no tongue required, and it works while feeding. Babies everywhere produce it first, and everywhere adults decide the baby means *her*.

Two unrelated families, thousands of miles apart, both built their word for mother out of the same accident. Linguists call these **nursery words** — and they are the one place where a resemblance between languages proves nothing at all.

Now go and check. Ask the German, Spanish and French tables for *two*, *three* and *night* — that is where the resemblance shows up fastest. Odia: ଦୁଇ *dui*, ତିନି *tini*, ରାତି *raati*.